

changes to rituals and customs. "We can go only by the present laws of the temple and they do not permit non-Hindus. We conducted *punyaham* as the laws were broken. But we will gladly welcome any timely changes in laws to bring them in tune with the times," says a spokesperson of the Chenas Namboodiri family, the traditional priests of Guruvayur temple. Rahul Eswar, a spokesperson of the Sabarimala temple, has said the changes being contemplated by scholars and priests would initiate another great reform movement in Hinduism. "But the Government should not try to push it through our throats." N. Gopalakrishnan, Hindu scholar and honorary director of Indian Institute of Scientific Heritage, says, "The ban is due to wrong interpretation of scriptures or sheer ignorance. Instead of trying to bash religion, we should try and change the wrong rituals."

The Guruvayur Devaswom Board has decided to discuss the government's directive to reform the outdated customs. However, Thottathil Raveendran, the board's president and a CPI(M) leader, says the reforms should be arrived at through consensus. "We will initiate discussions with religious organisations, socio-cultural and spiritual leaders and Vedic scholars. But we are against converting the temple into a tourist centre by doing away all restrictions."

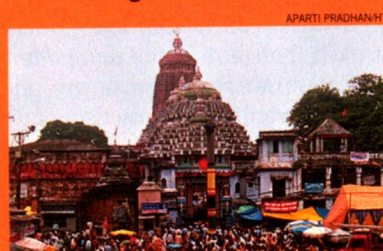
But there are strong dissenting voices too. "There should not be any change in the age-old rituals which have been established by Adi Sankara," insists a body of tantris and priests. High caste groups like the Malayala Brahmana Society and the politically important Nair Service Society (NSS) have strongly opposed any move by the government to change temple rituals. "No political party dares to touch the rituals of any other religion. But they kick around Hindu customs. We will not let the government touch the rituals as it would breach the Constitutional protection given to citizens to adhere to their respective customs and practices," said P.K. Narayana Panikkar, general secretary, NSS, which had supported the Vaikom Satyagraha of 1930s that led to Dalits being allowed into temples. The NSS has said that non-Hindus

QUIRK OF FAITH



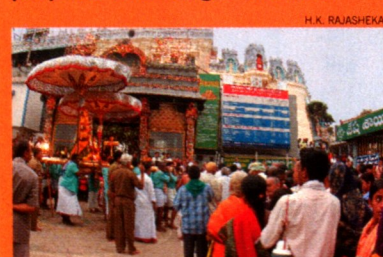
AYYAPPAN TEMPLE

LOCATION: Sabarimala, Kerala
Allows entry to persons of all religions except women in the menstrual age.



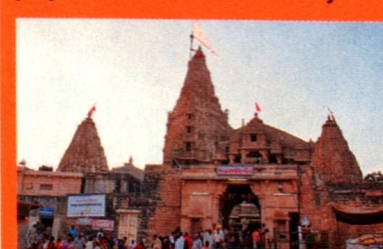
JAGANNATH TEMPLE

LOCATION: Puri, Orissa
Ban on Dalits. Open to Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists and Jains, but people of other religions barred.



VENKATESWARA TEMPLE

LOCATION: Tirupati, Andhra Pradesh
Non-Hindus not allowed except into the sixth hall. Muslims said to have prayed here in the 16th century.



DWARKADHISH TEMPLE

LOCATION: Dwarka, Gujarat
No discrimination on the basis of one's religion. Hindus, Muslims, Christians or Dalit, all can enter.

cannot enter temples just by saying that they believe in Hinduism.

The issue now threatens to acquire caste dimensions. The backward caste Hindu groups have come in support of changes in customs. Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalanayogam (SNDP), the powerful organisation of Ezhavas, an OBC community, is supporting the government's move for change. Vellappally Natesan, general secretary, SNDP, sees an upper caste conspiracy in sticking to traditional rituals. "Who has given the monopoly to NSS to champion the Hindu cause? It is the same old upper caste strategy to keep out lower castes," he said, pointing out that it was because Vayalar Ravi was an Ezhava that the tantris conducted the purification ceremonies for the second time. He is also supporting the second Guruvayur Satyagraha.

A few weeks before the *punyaham* incident, the Guruvayur temple's ban on non-Hindus was a subject of debate when Sudhakaran, the Marxist minister for temple administration, asked the temple board to consider admission to singer Yesudas. The ban on Yesudas has been in force for two decades ever since he was denied permission to hold a concert inside the temple. However, the debate died out after Yesudas intervened to say he would not like to enter a temple where he was not welcome. A few years ago the issue was in the news again after the Guruvayur temple barred entry to Kalamandalam Hyderali, a renowned Kathakali singer who died last year, on the grounds that he was a Muslim. Recently, authorities conducted a purification ceremony in a temple in Taliparamba in Kannur district after a Christian film actress, Meera Jasmine, offered prayers there. Last year, the famed Ayyappa temple at Sabarimala went through *punyaham* after a Kannada film actress claimed she had entered the temple which traditionally bars women of menstrual age.

Ironically, over 60 years ago, in response to popular movements, the then Maharajah of Travancore issued a proclamation allowing Dalits and untouchables to enter temples. What God's own country now needs is another benevolent ruler like him. ■